

Balaenoptera borealis

Sei whale



Length 55¼–65½ ft
(17–20 m)

Weight 22½–37 tons
(22–38 tonnes)

Social unit Group

Status Endangered

Location Worldwide (except Mediterranean, Baltic, Red Sea, Arabian Gulf)

Sei whales frequent more temperate waters (46–77° F/8–25° C) than their more widespread close cousins, the blue and fin whales. The sei whale is slender with a long, slim, pointed head and slightly downcurved jaw line. Its upper surfaces are dark gray, with a relatively sharp transition to the white or pale gray underside.

There are 320–340 close-spaced, delicate-fringed baleen plates hanging from each side of the upper jaw. These enable sei whales to take a variety of plankton, from copepods (water-flea-like crustaceans) less than ⅜ in (1 cm) across to schooling fish and squid 12 in (30 cm) long. Sei whales are usually

found in schools of 2–5 individuals. They rarely dive deeper than 1,000 ft (300 m), staying underwater for up to 20 minutes. Most births among sei whales are single, although twins occur occasionally.

approximately 50
throat grooves

*Balaenoptera acutorostrata*

Common Minke whale



Length 21¼–29 ft
(6.5–8.8 m)

Weight 2–3 tons
(2–2.7 tonnes)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern

Location Worldwide (except E. Mediterranean)

The smallest of the rorqual whales, the common minke whale has small baleen plates, 12 in (30 cm) long, with 230–360 in each side of the upper jaw. It has no universal migration pattern and is found in a variety of waters, including open ocean

and near ice sheets, coasts, fjords, and estuaries. It feeds alone by gulping in tight-knit swarms of krill or fish. Yet it is not shy, and will approach stationary boats. The 9¾-ft (3-m) calf is born in

midwinter and weaned after about 4 months. A smaller minke whale was recently recognized as a separate species—the Antarctic minke (*Balaenoptera bonaerensis*).

DOLPHINLIKE WHALE

The minke has a dolphinlike shape, with a sharp snout, pointed head, and a ridge from the snout up to the paired blowholes, which are set well back on the forehead. It is a speedy, agile swimmer, able to “surf” huge ocean breakers, and makes an occasional spectacular surface lunge.



smoky patches

*Megaptera novaeangliae*

Humpback whale



Length 49¼–55¾ ft
(15–17 m)

Weight 29½–33¼ tons
(30–34 tonnes)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern

Location Worldwide (except Mediterranean, Baltic, Red Sea, Arabian Gulf)

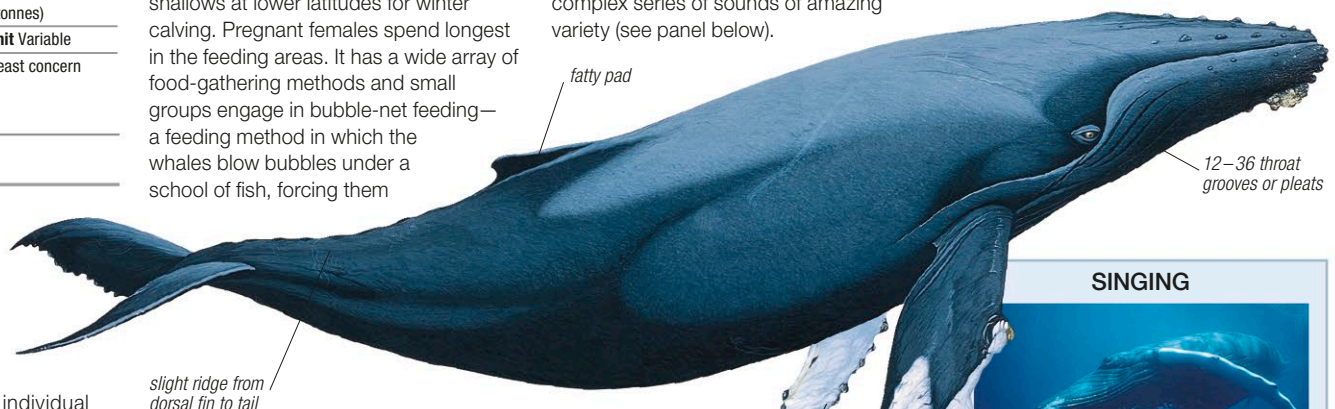
edges to the longest flippers of any animal. In spite of its size, it is graceful and athletic, being able to leap out of the water (see below). The humpback whale migrates from cold, food-rich summer waters near the poles to warmer, coastal shallows at lower latitudes for winter calving. Pregnant females spend longest in the feeding areas. It has a wide array of food-gathering methods and small groups engage in bubble-net feeding—a feeding method in which the whales blow bubbles under a school of fish, forcing them

upward. The whales then move up with open mouths and catch the fish. An extremely vocal whale, it also emits numerous sounds, perhaps partly to coordinate its feeding. In winter calving areas, solitary males produce a long, complex series of sounds of amazing variety (see panel below).

BODY AND FINS

The humpback whale has a dumpy body and a fatty pad at the base of the dorsal fin, which is variable in shape, from almost flat to tall and triangular. The span of the tail flukes is about one-third the length of the head and body.

The humpback whale is dark blue-black above, with paler or white patches below. Color variations, particularly on the underside of the tail, can be used to identify individual humpbacks, as can the knobbly leading



BREACHING

The humpback whale generates sufficient upward force with its tail to lift almost all of its 20-plus tons out of the water. It then twists in the air and falls on its back with a tremendous splash. It is not clear why whales “breach,” as such a movement out of the water is called. It may be to create massive sound waves or to ease irritation from skin parasites.



flippers up
to one-third
of total body
length

leading edge to flippers
(pectoral fins) has knobs
or tubercles

SINGING



The song of the male humpback whale develops from year to year. Lasting up to 30 minutes, it may attract females, warn off males, or be a form of sonar to detect other whales. Above, a male humpback moves into a singing posture, hanging vertically with head downward some 33–130 ft (10–40 m) below the surface.